is from Mick Jagger. ‘Hi, Jimmy,’ it reads. ‘I wanted to tell you how much you have given to me and my family watching you play for so long,’ he says, ‘and what an inspiration you’ve been to me to keep going.’ No one’s going to retire Mick Jagger, I think to myself, for a split second envious.

I am taking my daughter, Ruby, to play netball. The Test has finished early, only just stretching into a Saturday morning where it was full for my last ever hour of Test cricket at Lord’s, the same place it had all started. But today, somewhat abruptly, I’m no longer the leader of the England attack, I’m a dad with a teenage daughter who needs to be taken to netball. When our taxi arrives, my head rumbling, half grateful for the excuse not to be dwelling on the empty space and given some parental purpose, I drop her off at the game. After her first match, I feel the need to find somewhere to be alone, somewhere I can lie down, to process all this for a second, to get back to some of those messages, to ease the banging going on inside my head – that would be a godsend.

I dart out as the game finishes, avoiding the gaze of several parents looking at me with slightly upturned smiles and inward-facing eyebrows. I escape around the back of the sports hall, looking for anywhere I can just be alone, somewhere quiet and unburdened. *What am I looking for?*, I begin to ask myself, because it feels like a cave, or a cell, even a hole in the ground to bury myself in would suffice. I realise, though, on turning the corner, exactly where it is I need to be. On sight, it appears to be a mirage. A totally abandoned cricket pitch. There is no one on the horizon, nothing in my peripheries, just a vacated expanse of cricket outfield and a distant hut for a pavilion. When I approach it, body aching and creaking its way over, I see a single bench hugging the boundary. It is a bench not unlike the one I would travel to in Burnley, lost and alone. I find it, at first sitting and then, enjoying the silence, thinking it to be some sort of half-life between yesterday and tomorrow, I stretch out and lie there, completely alone. If I can just get ten minutes’ sleep here, that will be nice.

I don’t know how long I’ve been there when I get tapped on the shoulder. A man is there, but I don’t catch his face. He just says, as I come to, ‘You missing it that much already?’